

MANDAR DEODHAR

Shagufta Iqbal, 30
Content creator from Thane

Gaming avatar: Xyya

Play time: 10-12 hours a day

"I'd love to see a change in mindsets. There shouldn't be 'female' gamers, just 'gamers' because gaming is skill-based and there are no limitations in it"

Gaming for a Living

Most female gamers, on the other hand, want to be judged by their talent instead of their gender. Tarushika doesn't believe in standalone leagues or tournaments for women, adding that being in a female team can come with limited growth opportunities. "I felt I had more potential," she says about one such team she was in. Says Shagufta, "Gaming is skill-based and there are no limitations in skill." Raut feels that instituting gender-based leagues could bring more financial incentives for women gamers a la physical sports like football and cricket—"We can bring in partners who'd otherwise stay away from a very male-dominated sport"—but is reluctant. "If we do that, we are like any other sport," he says. "The beauty of gaming is that it doesn't have a gender barrier."

But as it stands, competitions alone cannot provide female gamers with the financial security they need to go pro. Saloni emphasises the need of having a side gig if you plan on going all in as an e-sports athlete. Shagufta found that the small number of stable teams and tournaments in India meant it's better to stream her rounds so she can grow an audience, get sponsorships and fatten her wallet. "Content creation gives me more freedom and helps popularise gaming," she says. "That's what I really want at the end of the day—to see the community grow." E-sport organisations like S8UL, Revenant ESports, Godlike and Alpha Zegus have started representing more female gamers and some, like Payal, have even collaborated with players at the ICC T20 World Cup and with global influencers like Mr. Beast and IShow Speed; she even got an audience with Prime Minister Narendra Modi two years ago as part of a round-table discussion on gaming. One of the most sought-after and highest-earning gaming creators, she was Streamer of the Year at the MOBIES Awards 2024, making her the first female gamer from India to win an international award.

But what comes first is always love of the game. Sonali puts in two to three hours daily. "When I am gaming, I want to relieve the stress I have had coding eight hours," she says. Saloni, who has come a long way from her first cheque as a gamer when she was 16, jokes, "My parents won't send me to Goa for a vacation, but will be okay if I go to Thailand for a tournament." The bonus: today, she's a much better gamer than her brother. ■